



ENG103: Research Writing Techniques

Mapping a Safe Course Through Research Ethics

Lesson outline

Research's Thorny Nature

Plagiarism

Integrity

Participant Consent

Participant Deception

Confidentiality and Anonymity

Power Relations

Harm Avoidance

Tips to Avoid Ethical Controversy

Homework

Research's Thorny Nature

Like the lizard (*Moloch horridus*) in the previous slide, research has many thorns that can get caught on competing ethical forces. Thus, it is important for researchers to have a good understanding of the complexities of research ethics.

In addition, ethics is a central issue when collecting information from human participants, and thus, it is important to be conscious of the fact that when dealing with people it is necessary to treat them with the dignity they would be normally given. For example, Oliver (2010) argues that:

In all research involving the collection of data from human beings, there is a fundamental moral requirement to treat those people in accord with standards and values which affirm their essential humanity. The research context is really no different in this respect from any other context in which human interaction takes place (p. 12).

Also, researchers have a responsibility to improve the lives of their research population (i.e., the group they are focused on, e.g., university students). For example, Oliver (2010) states that “perhaps the key issue is that in order to place research on a firm moral footing, there should at least be the intent to improve the human condition” (p. 12) .

Research's Thorny Nature

Ethics related to research can be separated into two categories:

- 1) The ethics of the research itself, which relates to its intrinsic and potential instrumental nature.
- 1) The ethics of the manner the research is conducted and how it collects data, especially regarding participant involved research.

Research's Thorny Nature

When discussing ethics and research it is important to be aware of the various ethical forces that may affect our research decisions.



Research's Thorny Nature

In addition to issues that relate to the competing ethical forces, plagiarism is also an ethical concern. Saldanha and O'Brien (2014) explain that:

Plagiarism is the use of somebody else's work as if it were your own. However, it is much more than taking a published author's words (or pictures) and using them in your own work without giving an appropriate reference. Plagiarism also includes the use of the ideas of other people (such as a fellow colleague or student) and even the re-use of one's own work, without acknowledgement (p. 48).

The ways to avoid plagiarism, even accidental plagiarism, is as follows:

- Keep detailed notes of where you source information from including page numbers
- Always reference another's specific ideas
- Always reference direct quotes
- Adhere to an academic referencing system such as the APA style.

Research's Thorny Nature

Integrity also relates to ethics; it refers to the honesty and reliability of the research.

Research that omits data, which it collected, so to uphold a particular position is dishonest and unreliable and ultimately unethical.

Similarly, research that only targets specific participants for the collection of data knowing it will affect the net results and thus uphold a particular position is dishonest and unreliable and ultimately unethical.

Research's Thorny Nature

Being aware of ethical issues is key to mapping a safe journey through research ethics. Accordingly, a researcher, after formalizing a research plan, should contemplate the answers to the following questions:

- 1) Is my research intrinsically ethically controversial in my or other countries?
- 2) Does my research have the potential to be instrumentally ethically controversial in my or other domains?
- 3) Are my research methods ethically controversial in my or other countries?
- 4) Are my methods to collect data balanced or driven by a biased agenda?

Also, after the collection of the data, researchers should contemplate the answers to the following questions:

- 1) Is the representation of my findings honest and balanced?
- 2) Have I correctly acknowledged my reliance on the work of others?

Moreover, there are five key ethical factors to consider while collecting data from human participants, which are: 1) Participant Consent, 2) Participant Deception, 3) Confidentiality and Anonymity, 4) Power Relations, and 5) Harm Avoidance.

Participant Consent

In general, any research that requires the collection of data from participants through interviews, focus groups and questionnaires requires the consent of the participant. Saldanha and O'Brien (2014) state that:

Informed consent is one of the core principles in ethically-designed research. It is the responsibility of the researcher to ensure that participants fully understand what they are consenting to participate in (p. 43).

Also, regarding informed consent Piper and Simons (2005) explain that:

This means that those interviewed or observed should give their permission in full knowledge of the purpose of the research and the consequences for them of taking part (p. 56).

Participant Consent

Obtaining the participants consent is normally obtained from them signing (or agreeing by other means) to a consent form that typically:

- ▶ Contains the details of the researcher and their institutional authority
- ▶ Contains a statement that the participants involvement is completely voluntary and there is no compulsion
- ▶ Outlines the aims of the research
- ▶ Outlines the participant's role
- ▶ Includes a statement that the participant can withdraw at any point
- ▶ Includes a statement with an explanation that the participant's personal details will not be disclosed. This can also include a statement that their personal information will be destroyed and only an alias will be attached to their responses

Research that does not gain the participants' informed consent is an ethical violation of participant consent. However, a potential problem with a consent form that outlines the aims of the research and the participants role in achieving those aims in detail is that it may influence the behavior of the participant and thus invalidate the authenticity of their responses.

Participant Deception

Participant Deception typically refers to the concealment of the true aim of the research or the true nature of the participants involvement so not to affect their behavior and produce unnatural responses. This can be achieved through the misrepresentation of the research or the omission of key details.

Also, it can refer to collecting data through observation without receiving the consent of those being observed.

Deception used to be more common but now its use is restricted because its potential effects on the participants feelings are given more consideration.

For example, Saldanha and O'Brien (2014) argue that:

In the past, some level of deception regarding the focus of a research project was acceptable, but more recently this has come to be seen as unacceptable if the participant is likely to object or show discomfort once he or she has been debriefed (p. 45).

Thus, if data is obtained from participants through deceptive means, it would be an ethical violation through Participant Deception.

Confidentiality and Anonymity

When conducting participant-based research confidentiality and anonymity are key issues related to research ethics.

Regarding confidentiality Piper and Simons (2005) explain that: Confidentiality is a principle that allows people not only to talk in confidence, but also to refuse to allow publication of any material that they think might harm them in any way (p. 57).

For example, without the guarantee of confidentiality students would not be willing to explain their true feelings in research interviews designed to assess student satisfaction.

In relation to anonymity Piper and Simons (2005) suggest that “anonymization is a procedure to offer some protection of privacy and confidentiality” (p. 57). For example, giving participants an alias or a reference number at the first point of contact is a mechanism of anonymization.

In essence, confidentiality refers to the secrecy of participants to the extent their involvement in the research is not disclosed, while anonymity relates to the procedures used to achieve and maintain confidentiality. Thus, if researchers disclose the personal information of a participant this would be an ethical violation of Confidentiality and Anonymity.

Power Relations

Power relations is an important issue to consider because it can force people to participate in a research project, and it can influence their responses.

For example, Saldanha and O'Brien (2014) state that:

Participation in a research study should be voluntary and withdrawal without question should be guaranteed. However, as with all aspects of life, power relations can interfere with these aspirations. It is important for the researcher to be aware of such power relations and the impact they might have on participants (p. 45).

Situations where power relations may be a matter of concern:

- A lecturer collecting data from student participants
- A researcher from a powerful culture extracting data from participants who belong to a marginalized culture
- An employer collecting data from their staff participants

Issues in power relations may result in:

- Participants behaving in a manner they think is favourable to the researcher
- Participants feeling they are compelled to participate in the research

Thus, if a researcher uses their position to coerce participants to take part in their research or to respond to a questionnaire in a particular way this would be an ethical violation of Power Relations.

Harm Avoidance

Harm Avoidance refers to the application of measures to avoid harming participants. Research that harms participants is unethical. The harm can be financial, material, physical and emotional and can occur in several research situations. Below are some examples,

A situation where interviews or other forms of data collection are seen to be an act of collusion with an opposed culture could cause participants to face repercussions from their culture merely for taking part. This would be an ethical violation.

A situation where a participant is identified after revealing information such as a complaint against an employer could cause the participant to face financial harm. This would be an ethical violation.

A situation where distressing information is revealed during an interview and triggers the interviewee severe emotional stress is an ethical violation.

A situation where a participant loses university marks in an exam or an assignment directly due to a research experiment is an ethical violation.

Thus, if a researcher through the collection of data from participants causes a participant harm it will be a ethical violation of Harm Avoidance.

Harm Avoidance

There are a several approaches that help reduce the potential harm a participant can be exposed to. These are as follows:

- ▶ Always ensure participants are unidentifiable from the point of collecting data
- ▶ Never include data in your report that could lead to the identification of a participant
- ▶ When appropriate, paraphrase the participants responses when discussing them in your report
- ▶ When possible, aggregate the responses of participants
- ▶ Avoid singling out a participant in a manner they can identify it is them you are referring to, if they were to read your research
- ▶ Allow the participant to give you feedback related to the manner you have used data collected from them.
- ▶ Always ensure to avoid dynamics (e.g., power relations) that may make the participant feel they are obliged to participate or to respond in a particular way.

Tips to avoid ethical controversy

- ▶ When possible, limit your direct data collection from participants
- ▶ Always keep participants anonymous
- ▶ Avoid referring to specific participants quotes or unique situations
- ▶ When relevant follow your institution's (e.g., PSU's) guidelines
- ▶ Allow colleagues and peers to critically review your research plans
- ▶ Be transparent in the final report
- ▶ Highlight your research flaws and limitations in the final report
- ▶ Acknowledge your own subjectivity

Class exercise

Dr Bosco's Application

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Dr Bosco's application submitted to Lewisham College (available on LMS), and working in your groups undertake the following:

1. correctly identify if there are ethical violations
2. justify your claims, which involves explaining why the situations and or actions are ethical violations
3. explain ways to remedy the ethical violations you identified, which involves you explaining how the research should be conducted.
4. Write and submit your responses to the above three points to the LMS homework submission in week 9, which is titled "Ethics Homework".

Class exercise

Dr Bosco's Application

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Dr Bosco's research proposal violated ethics by:

- 1) not intending to gain informed consent from the participants and their parents.
- 2) exploiting power relations to recruit participants
- 3) having the likely potential to cause the participants psychological harm and negatively affect their learning.

In terms of remedying the ethical violations, Dr Bosco must completely redesign the research, so it does not have the potential to cause harm to the students. This can be achieved by limiting the experiment to one classroom activity in which the experimental group has to wear a distinct colour blazer while the control group wears the standard black blazer. Also, written informed consent must be obtained from the parents and students before the experiment is undertaken. In addition, to avoid the issues related to power relations Dr Brasco should recruit student participants he does not directly teach.

References

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